

from the OpenLDAP server to the Active Directory server. This option is an acceptable solution if one wants to set the password only using the Linux environment and have these changes migrate to the Active Directory server.

Passwords can be written to the Active Directory provided they can be sent in clear text. This imposes the constraint that LDAP must store it in clear text or in a two-way encryption scheme. So, the password cannot be stored as a MD5 or SHA hashed string in the LDAP server.

This constraint raises issues of trust. In fact, the best solution is based on trust. An excellent resource is 'PIG: Practical Interoperability Guide' at <http://pig.made-it.com/>. Active Directory uses Kerberos. Linux and OpenLDAP can use Kerberos authentication. Although Microsoft's implementation of Kerberos is not identical to that of MIT Kerberos, it can be set up to trust a MIT Kerberos server as well. Hence, it is possible to keep the password store in a MIT Kerberos server, which is used by both the Windows and Linux environments (<http://pig.made-it.com/kerberos.html>).

Finally, projects like FreeIPA (<http://freepa.org/>)

make it easier to manage the whole set up, including selective delegation of administration rights.

The tragedy is that every organisation's infrastructure starts small and all this complexity seems unnecessary. Each little addition to the infrastructure is a small increment. After a while, it is too huge an effort to change. The same practices continue until a disruptive change is forced on the organisation. Instead, it is desirable that systems administrators think about the best practices for access controls and implement them early before the need becomes apparent. Even if the organisation does not expand, at least the skill sets of the systems administrators would have grown! 

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